ml-ladder · Part E writeup · compiled 2026-10-30

Generative models

Compiled from `docs/writeups/e-generative.md`. Every number in it comes from the JSON under `docs/writeups/data/`, and every figure from `docs/writeups/figures/`.

Status

Status: complete (E1–E5) · **Constraint:** MNIST subsets, short budgets; E4 gives all three families one identical budget
Numbers: seeds 0–2, reference seed 0 · raw values in `data/e-metrics.json`
Reproduce: `ladder run E1 … E5` (needs `uv sync --extra torch`), or `uv run python tools/writeup_figures.py E`
Hardware: E1–E4 swept on a Colab T4; E5 is arithmetic, and FLUX.1-schnell itself ran on a Kaggle T4 (record)

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What part E settled 20

Every model before this part was trained to be *right*: there was a label, and the score counted how often the prediction matched it. A generative model is trained to be *plausible*, and plausibility is not a quantity any single number captures. So part E is really about measurement — the models are the easy part.

The three families make three different bargains. A **VAE** optimizes a bound on the likelihood, so its loss means something, and pays for that with a latent space it must keep close to a prior. A **GAN** optimizes nothing in particular: two networks play a game and the loss is a scoreboard in it, which is why its loss curve says almost nothing about sample quality. **Diffusion** replaces the adversary with a fixed corruption process and a regression, buying stability at a sampling cost measured in orders of magnitude. E4 puts all three on one budget; E5 reads what the production descendants of E3 actually look like.

Scoring is shared in `src/mlladder/generative.py`: a small classifier trained on the data provides a feature space, and a Fréchet distance between Gaussians fitted in it provides the number. That is exactly FID's construction with a different feature extractor, so it is called **fd** everywhere and is comparable across these rungs and with nothing published. Mode collapse gets its own metric, because a collapsed generator can post a respectable fd — its feature mean and covariance are simply wrong in a way that averages out — so the samples are classified and the histogram's normalized entropy reported alongside.

Notation: β is the KL weight, $\bar{\alpha}_t$ the surviving signal at diffusion step t, and fd is the Fréchet distance described above.

E1 — The ELBO is two terms, and they disagree

Question. A VAE's loss sums a reconstruction and a KL. What does trading one against the other actually do to the model?

The idea

A **generative model** learns to produce new samples that look like its training data: here, new handwritten digits.

A **variational autoencoder (VAE)** starts from an ordinary autoencoder, which squeezes an image through a small **latent code** z and reconstructs it. A plain autoencoder's codes can be scattered anywhere, so picking a random code and decoding it gives garbage. The VAE fixes this in two moves:

1. the encoder outputs a *distribution* over codes (a mean μ and a spread σ per latent dimension) instead of a single point, and the decoder is trained on a *sample* from it;
2. a penalty (the **KL divergence**) pulls every such distribution towards a standard normal $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$.

After training, the codes fill the standard normal, so a new image is generated by drawing $z \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$ and decoding it.

The encoder produces μ and σ. The sample $z = \mu + \sigma\epsilon$ is drawn in a way gradients can pass through (the reparameterization trick). The loss balances reconstruction quality against the KL "rate", and β sets the exchange rate between them.

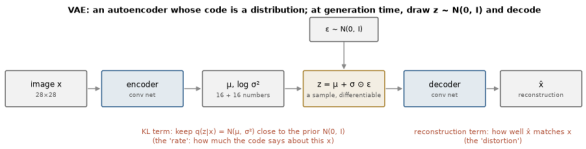


Figure 1. The VAE pipeline

The math

The bound. The likelihood is intractable, so the VAE optimizes

$$\log p(x) \geq \mathbb{E}_{q(z|x)}\left[\log p(x \mid z)\right] - D_{KL}\big(q(z \mid x) \,\|\, p(z)\big)\,,$$

a reconstruction term minus a KL term. Read them as **rate and distortion**: the KL is how many nats the code carries about this particular x, the reconstruction is what is lost. β sets the exchange rate, and each end has a failure mode — too little KL and the aggregate posterior drifts from the prior so sampling from $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$ produces nonsense, too much and the latent carries nothing.

The KL is closed form because both distributions are Gaussian:

$$D_{KL} = -\tfrac{1}{2}\sum_j \left(1 + \log \sigma_j^2 - \mu_j^2 - \sigma_j^2\right),$$

which is most of why that prior is chosen. Left unreduced over j it also detects **posterior collapse**: a dimension whose KL is ∼0 is one the encoder has abandoned to the prior.

The reparameterization trick is what makes any of it trainable. Sampling $z \sim q(z \mid x)$ has no gradient with respect to μ and σ, because the randomness sits between them and the loss. Writing $z = \mu + \sigma\epsilon$ with $\epsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$ makes the sample a *deterministic* function of the parameters plus parameter-free noise, and the gradient flows.

What we measure, and why

- **Reconstruction** (negative log-likelihood of the image given its code, summed over pixels) — how much is lost passing through the latent. Lower is sharper.
- **KL, or rate** (in nats) — how much information the code carries about each particular image. The trade-off between these two *is* the β dial.
- **Active units** — latent dimensions whose KL is meaningfully above zero. A dimension with KL ≈ 0 carries nothing: the encoder has abandoned it (**posterior collapse**). The loss cannot show this, so it is counted.
- **fd (Fréchet distance) of generated samples** — how close the *generated* digits are to real ones, in a classifier's feature space (defined in the part introduction, and see E4). Reconstruction scores the autoencoder, fd scores the generator. They are different questions.

What I built

A convolutional VAE with a 16-dimensional latent, swept over β. The reconstruction is summed over pixels and the KL over latent dimensions — a test pins this, because

averaging one and summing the other silently rescales β by the pixel count, which is the most common way this loss is got wrong.

Results

Setup: 12k MNIST, 12 epochs; medians over seeds 0–2.

β	reconstruction	KL (rate)	active units	fd(samples)
0.25	**76.7**	37.0	16/16	5.09
1.0	84.7	23.4	16/16	**4.44**
4.0	117.6	9.8	16/16	6.4
16.0	184.7	1.1	**6/16**	19.31

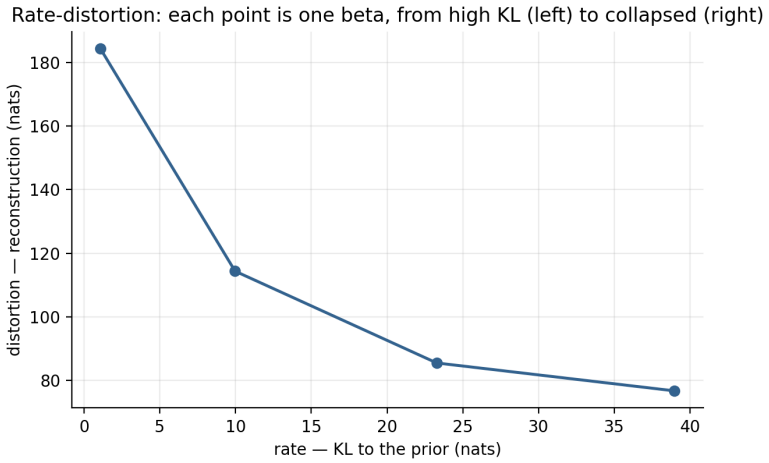


Figure 2. Rate-distortion

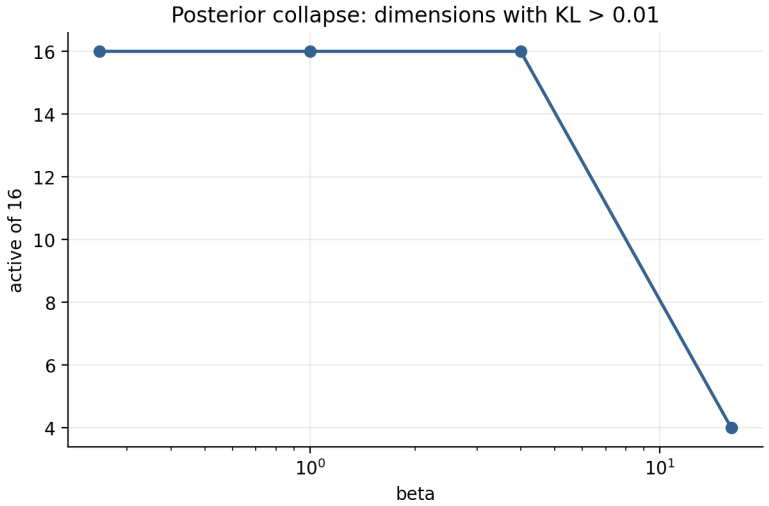


Figure 3. Active units

What surprised me

Not the trade-off — that is the theory working — but how *cleanly* the collapse arrives. At $\beta = 16$ the encoder has abandoned 10 of its 16 dimensions (range 9–12 across seeds), the rate has fallen to 1.1 nats, and sample quality is more than four times worse. The training loss went down the whole time. "The loss is decreasing" is fully

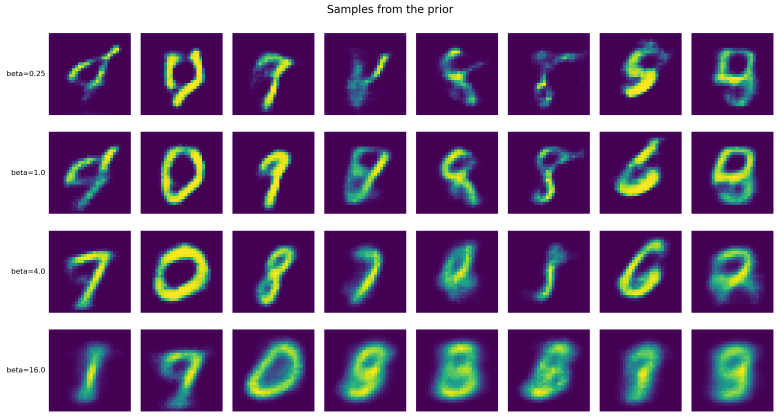


Figure 4. Samples

compatible with the model having quietly stopped using its latent space, which is the entire reason active units are counted rather than assumed.

What I expected and did not get: a disagreement between the ELBO and sample quality. `best/agree` is 1.0 on every seed — both pick $\beta = 1$. At this budget the bound and the proxy point the same way, and I have recorded that rather than the more interesting story I was looking for.

Open threads

A free-bits or KL-warmup schedule, which is the standard fix for collapse and would show whether the abandoned dimensions can be recovered. A larger latent, where collapse should arrive earlier. And a discrete latent (VQ-VAE), which sidesteps the rate-distortion dial entirely.

Further reading

Auto-Encoding Variational Bayes; beta-VAE; Alemi et al., *Fixing a Broken ELBO*, on rate-distortion as the right frame.

E2 — The objective in the theorem, and the one everybody uses

Question. The GAN paper proves its result for a minimax objective that practitioners immediately replaced. Does the replacement matter, and how would you see it?

The idea

A **generative adversarial network (GAN)** trains two networks against each other. The **generator** G turns random noise into an image. The **discriminator** D looks at an image and outputs the probability that it is real. D is trained to catch fakes, and G is trained to fool D. If both improve, G's images become indistinguishable from real ones.

There is no reconstruction and no likelihood. G never sees a real image directly; everything it learns arrives through D's gradient. That makes GANs sharp (no averaging,

so no blur) and notoriously unstable. The losses are moves in a game, not measures of quality, so a falling loss curve means little.

The rung compares two versions of the generator's objective that have the same theoretical optimum but behave very differently early in training.

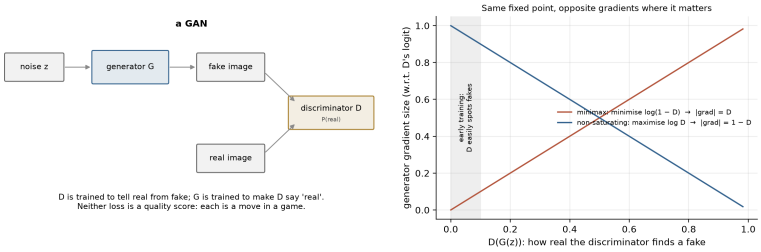


Figure 5. The GAN game, and the two generator objectives

Right: gradient size for the generator as a function of how convincing its fake is to D. Early in training D easily rejects fakes, the grey band on the left. There the original minimax loss gives almost no gradient, exactly when the generator most needs one, while the non-saturating loss gives a large one.

The math

The game. The discriminator maximizes $\log D(x) + \log(1 - D(G(z)))$; at the optimum for a fixed generator it recovers the density ratio, and the generator's objective becomes the Jensen-Shannon divergence. That is the theorem.

The problem with it. The generator is asked to *minimize* $\log(1 - D(G(z)))$. Early in training $D(G(z)) \approx 0$, and

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial s} \log(1 - \sigma(s)) = -\sigma(s) \to 0 \quad \text{as } s \to -\infty,$$

so the gradient vanishes exactly when the generator is worst and most needs one. The **non-saturating** form instead maximizes $\log D(G(z))$, whose gradient is $1 - \sigma(s) \to 1$ in that same limit. Identical fixed point, opposite behaviour where it matters. Both are implemented and tested here against that limit directly.

What we measure, and why

- **fd** — sample quality in a classifier's feature space. Lower is better. Scored *during* training too, because GAN losses do not track quality.
- **Coverage** — the fraction of the ten digit classes that appear among generated samples, per a pretrained classifier.
- **Mode entropy** — normalised entropy of the predicted-class histogram: 1 when all ten digits appear equally often, 0 when the generator produces one digit only (**mode collapse**, the characteristic GAN failure). It is reported separately because a collapsed generator can still post a respectable fd.

What I built

A DCGAN at the paper's structural rules — strided convolutions, batch norm everywhere except the generator's output and discriminator's input, Adam at $\beta_1 = 0.5$ — with both generator objectives as arms, quality scored *during* training as well as at the end, and mode coverage measured by classifying the samples.

Results

Setup: 12k MNIST, 14 epochs; medians over seeds 0–2.

arm	fd	coverage	mode entropy
non-saturating	**1.84** [1.73, 2.00]	1.00	0.878
minimax	2.02 [1.81, 2.09]	1.00	0.870

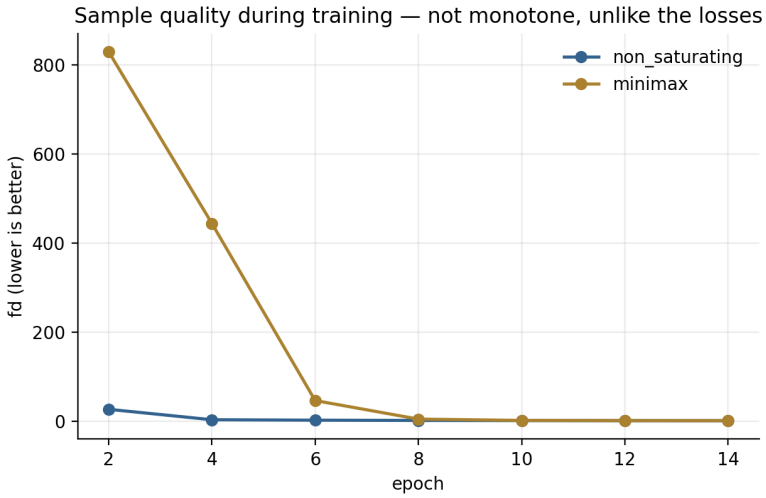


Figure 6. Quality trace

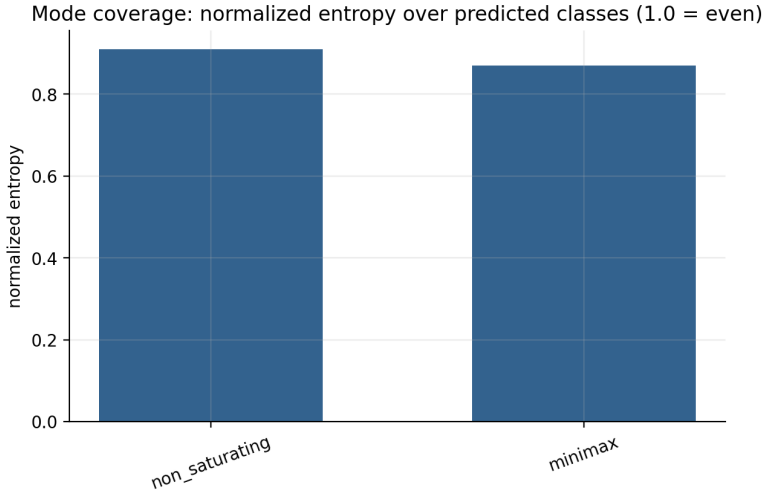


Figure 7. Mode coverage

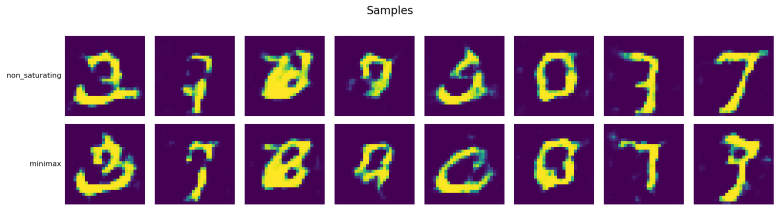


Figure 8. Samples

What surprised me, and a claim I have to withdraw

On a single CPU run at seed 0, the minimax arm **collapsed completely**: fd 590.83, all ten thousand samples classified as one digit, mode entropy exactly 0, and a generator loss pinned at −0.000 from epoch 4 — the saturation the derivative predicts, arriving exactly on cue. I reported that as the rung's headline: a 320× difference from choosing the objective the theorem states.

It does not replicate. The three-seed GPU sweep gives minimax fd 2.02 against non-saturating's 1.84 — a real but modest +0.098 — with full mode coverage on every seed. **Seed 0 on the GPU scores 1.81 where seed 0 on the CPU scored 590.83.** Same code, same seed, same objective; the difference is the device.

That is a more interesting result than the one I withdrew, and a worse one for anybody reporting GAN numbers. The saturating objective does not reliably fail — it sits close enough to a failure boundary that floating-point differences between two devices decide whether it trains at all. Part C found the same phenomenon in C2 and I concluded there that it was specific to a threshold metric near its threshold; here it is the *model* near a threshold, and the consequence is total rather than third-decimal.

The honest summary: the non-saturating form is better by about 0.1 fd on average, and is dramatically more robust in a way a three-seed sweep on one device still understates.

Open threads

Repeating the sweep on both devices to quantify how often minimax collapses rather than noting that it can. WGAN-GP, whose entire premise is that the JS divergence is the wrong distance when the supports barely overlap. And a discriminator-to-generator update ratio sweep.

Further reading

Generative Adversarial Networks; DCGAN; Wasserstein GAN.

E3 — A fixed corruption process, and the dial it leaves you holding

Question. Diffusion removes the adversary and the bound. What does it charge for that, and where is the charge set?

The idea

A **diffusion model** learns to generate by learning to *denoise*. Take a training image and add a little Gaussian noise, then a little more, over hundreds of steps, until nothing but noise is left. This **forward process** is fixed and needs no learning. Then train a network to reverse one step at a time: given a noisy image and how noisy it is, predict the noise that was added.

To generate, start from pure noise and apply the learned denoiser step by step until an image emerges. The training objective is a plain regression (predict the noise, squared error), so there is no adversary to balance and no bound to tune, which is why

diffusion trains stably. The price is paid at sampling time: one network evaluation per step.

The **noise schedule** decides how quickly signal is destroyed across the steps, and it is the main design choice left.

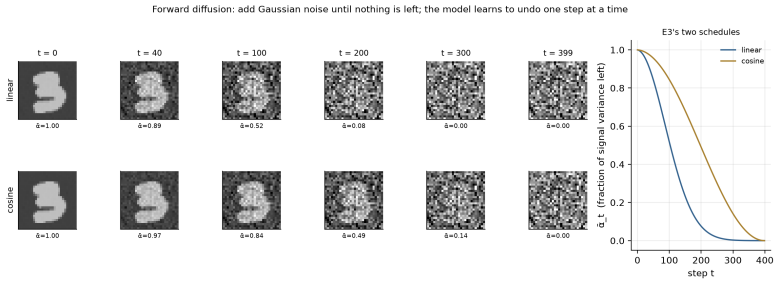


Figure 9. Forward diffusion under E3's two schedules

A real MNIST digit noised by the rung's own schedules. The linear schedule has destroyed almost all the signal by step 200 ($\bar{\alpha} = 0.08$) and spends the rest of its steps on near-pure noise. The cosine schedule keeps signal longer and spreads the destruction more evenly. The denoiser (a small U-Net) learns to undo these steps.

The math

The forward process destroys an image with a fixed, *unlearned* Markov chain

$$q(x_t \mid x_{t-1}) = \mathcal{N}\left(x_t; \sqrt{1-\beta_t}\, x_{t-1},\ \beta_t I\right),$$

and because Gaussians compose, t steps of it collapse into one:

$$q(x_t \mid x_0) = \mathcal{N}\left(x_t; \sqrt{\bar{\alpha}_t}\, x_0,\ (1-\bar{\alpha}_t) I\right), \qquad \bar{\alpha}_t = \prod_{s \le t} (1-\beta_s).$$

That closed form is the reason training is cheap: a step draws one random t and jumps straight there, never simulating the chain.

The objective. The variational bound on $\log p(x)$ decomposes into per-step KLs between $q(x_{t-1} \mid x_t, x_0)$ and the model's reverse step. Both are Gaussian with known variances, so each KL is a squared difference of means, and reparameterizing the mean in terms of the noise reduces the whole bound (up to weights DDPM drops) to

$$\mathcal{L} = \mathbb{E}_{t, x_0, \epsilon}\left[\left\| \epsilon - \epsilon_\theta\left(\sqrt{\bar{\alpha}_t} x_0 + \sqrt{1-\bar{\alpha}_t}\,\epsilon,\ t\right)\right\|^2\right].$$

A regression onto noise. No bound to be loose, no adversary to out-run — which is the stability diffusion is famous for.

The schedule is the design surface that survives. $\bar{\alpha}_t$ determines the signal-to-noise ratio at every step, and therefore how the difficulty of the denoising task is distributed over t. The linear schedule reaches near-total destruction early and then spends most of its steps on nearly-pure noise, where there is little left to learn; the cosine schedule sets $\bar{\alpha}_t \propto \cos^2\left(\frac{t/T+s}{1+s} \cdot \frac{\pi}{2}\right)$ so signal survives longer.

What we measure, and why

- **fd against the number of sampling steps** (10 to 400) — the quality/speed trade-off, which is diffusion's defining cost. The model is trained once, with 400 steps, and sampled with fewer by skipping.
- **Sampling seconds** — the other axis of that trade-off, measured directly.
- **The "knee"** — the fewest steps within 10% of full-step quality. It summarises the curve as one number: how much speed you can buy cheaply.
- **Linear vs cosine**, over three seeds — whether the published improvement holds at this scale (it does not).

What I built

A 245k-parameter U-Net with a sinusoidal timestep embedding, $T = 400$ training steps, both schedules as arms, and sampling swept over $\{10, 25, 50, 100, 400\}$ steps with quality and wall-clock recorded at each.

A bug the tests caught before the results did. DDPM's $\beta \in [10^{-4}, 0.02]$ is specified *for* $T = 1000$. Used unscaled at $T = 400$ it leaves $\bar{\alpha}_T = 0.017$ — the forward process never reaches $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$, while the sampler starts from one. The training loss is completely blind to this; it shows up only as bad samples, and it would have turned the schedule comparison into a measurement of my own mistake. A test asserting $\bar{\alpha}_T < 0.01$ for every schedule failed, and the range is now scaled by $1000/T$.

Results

Setup: 12k MNIST, 16 epochs, 500 samples; medians over seeds 0–2.

sampling steps	linear fd	cosine fd	seconds
10	**2.95**	24.32 [8.97, 153.0]	0.44
25	1.79	10.84	1.11
50	**1.40**	7.51	2.23
100	1.62	3.56	4.41
400	1.56 [1.42, 2.23]	2.27 [1.25, 2.50]	17.0

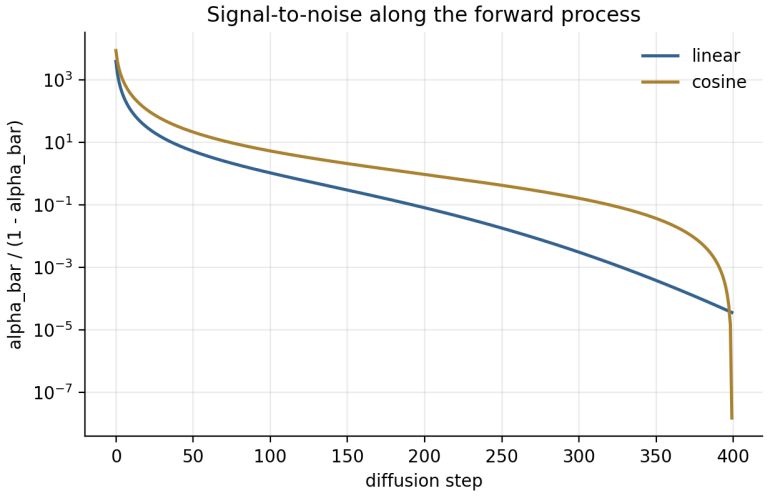


Figure 10. Schedules

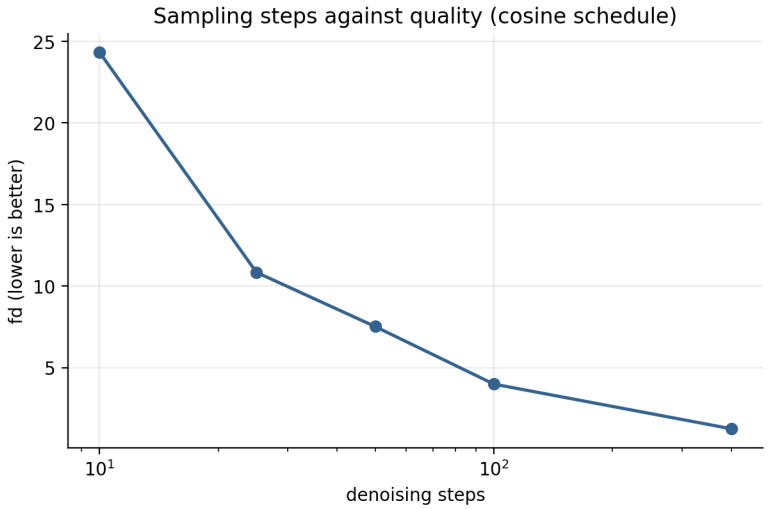


Figure 11. Steps against quality

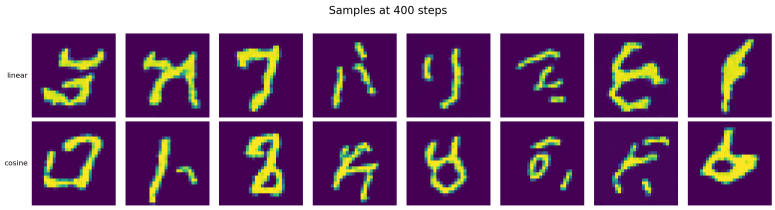


Figure 12. Samples

What surprised me

Two things, and the second retracts a claim.

The knee is a property of the schedule, not of diffusion. On the cosine schedule, quality is still improving at 400 steps — `steps/knee` is 400, meaning no cheaper setting lands within 10% of the full-step score, and 10 steps costs +23.07 fd for a 38× speedup. On the *linear* schedule the same model is within 10% of its full-step quality at **50 steps**, and at 50 steps it is actually better than at 400 (1.40 against 1.56). Reporting "diffusion needs hundreds of steps" from the cosine row alone would have been a statement about one schedule dressed up as a statement about the method.

Cosine does not beat linear here. I expected it to — it is the standard improvement, and at $T = 400$ with a cosine $\bar{\alpha}$ the low-SNR steps really are less wasted. The measurement says otherwise: `cosine_gain/fd` has a median of **−0.036** with a seed range of [−1.075, +0.308], straddling zero, and at every truncated step count linear wins outright. The honest reading is that cosine's advantage is a large-T, large-model result and this rung is neither; the schedule that keeps more signal alive also leaves more of the denoising work to the last few steps, which is exactly what makes it fragile under truncation. Both schedules cover all ten digits on every seed, so this is a fidelity difference, not a collapse.

Open threads

DDIM's deterministic sampler, which is the actual answer to the step count and would separate "few steps" from "few steps with this sampler". A $T = 1000$ run to test the large-T explanation for cosine directly. And v- or velocity-prediction, which is what E5's production descendants use.

Further reading

Denoising Diffusion Probabilistic Models; Improved DDPM for the cosine schedule; DDIM.

E4 — One budget, three families, and a column that turned out to be a trap

Question. "Which generative model is best" has no answer until the column is named. So: name four columns, give all three families identical data and an identical budget, and see how many different models win.

The idea

E1–E3 each built one family. E4 trains all three (VAE, GAN, diffusion) on the **same data, for the same number of epochs**, and scores them on the same scorecard. The point is that "which generative model is best?" has no answer until you say best *at what*: sample quality, covering every kind of digit, originality, training cost and sampling cost can each crown a different winner.

The models are imported from their own rungs, not rewritten, so any difference comes from the family and the budget, not from reimplementation.

Scoring generative models is hard, because there is no label to compare with. The standard trick, used throughout this part, is to embed real and generated images with a classifier trained on the real data, fit a Gaussian to each cloud of feature vectors, and measure the distance between the two Gaussians (the **Fréchet distance**, which is how FID is built). It has a blind spot, which is why it never appears alone.

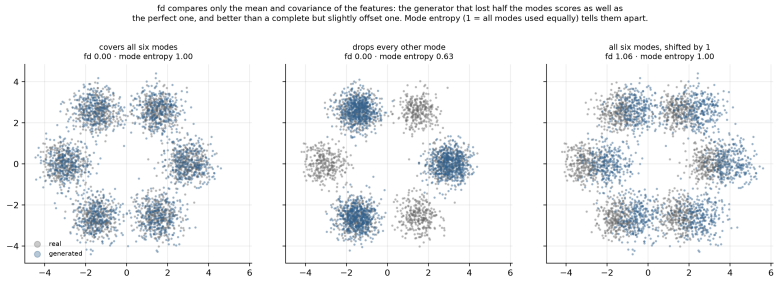


Figure 13. What Fréchet distance can and cannot see

Three generators against the same six-mode "real" distribution (grey). One that keeps only every other mode has exactly the same mean and covariance as the real data, so its Fréchet distance is 0.00, as good as perfect. A complete generator shifted by one unit scores worse. Mode entropy exposes the first (0.63 instead of 1.00), which is why E4 reports both.

The math

There is no new objective here — the point is that the three losses *cannot be compared*. E1 minimizes negative nats, E2 minimizes an adversarial scoreboard whose optimum is $\log 4$ regardless of sample quality, E3 minimizes a denoising MSE against noise.

Three different units, three different fixed points, no ordering between them. Every comparison therefore has to happen in a space none of them was trained in:

$$d_F^2 = \|\mu_r - \mu_g\|^2 + \mathrm{tr}\left(\Sigma_r + \Sigma_g - 2(\Sigma_r\Sigma_g)^{1/2}\right),$$

the Fréchet distance between Gaussians fitted to a shared classifier's features — FID's construction with a local feature extractor. That statistic has a known weakness: it is a function of the first two moments only, so a generator that drops modes can compensate with a wider covariance. Hence the second column, normalized entropy over the classifier's predictions, and the third, mean distance to the nearest training image — because a model that memorized the data wins fd and coverage dishonestly.

The floor. A Fréchet distance has no absolute scale, so a held-out sample of real data is scored against the real reference too. That row is what makes any other row readable.

What we measure, and why

- **fd** — distributional quality, as above. The **real-data row** (held-out real images scored against the reference) gives the floor any generator could hope to reach. Without it, fd has no scale.
- **Coverage and mode entropy** — are all ten digits generated, and in balanced amounts? This catches what fd misses.
- **Nearest-neighbour distance** — mean distance from each generated image to its closest *training* image. Too small means the model memorised its training set, which would win the other columns dishonestly.
- **Training seconds and seconds per 1000 samples** — the costs, which differ across families by three orders of magnitude.
- **Budget sensitivity** — the same diffusion model scored at 14 and 16 epochs, added after the first results looked wrong. It measures whether an equal-budget comparison is comparing families or comparing how far each got.

What I built

All three models are imported from their own rungs, not reimplemented, trained on the same 12k MNIST images for 14 epochs, and scored on quality, coverage, novelty, training seconds and sampling seconds. Plus one control, which turned out to matter more than the scorecard.

Results

Setup: medians over seeds 0–2.

	fd	coverage	mode entropy	nn distance	train	sample 1k
real data	**0.094**	—	—	4.60	—	—
GAN	**1.76**	1.00	**0.898**	6.28	7.9s	0.0073s
VAE	3.79	1.00	0.790	5.24	**5.0s**	**0.0038s**
diffusion	25.32 [10.3, 27.6]	0.70	0.324	7.23	41.4s	8.58s

The cost column is the part that generalizes beyond this budget: diffusion's sampling costs **1,171× the GAN's** for a thousand images, because it runs its network once per denoising step and the GAN runs it once.

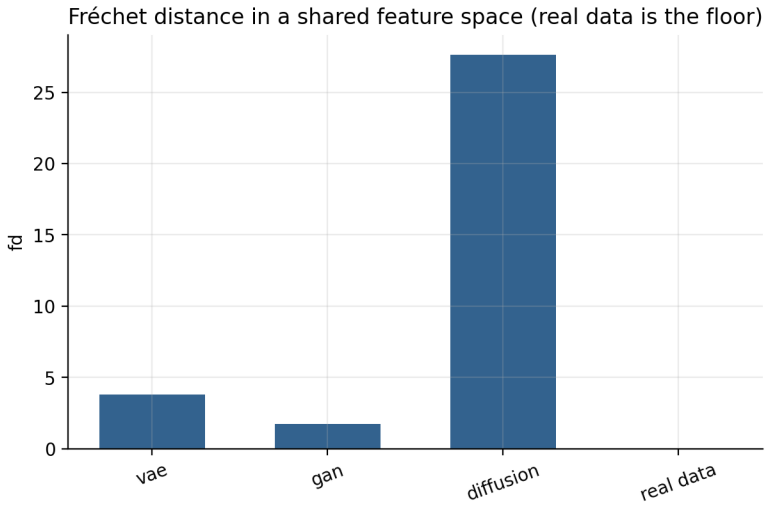


Figure 14. Quality

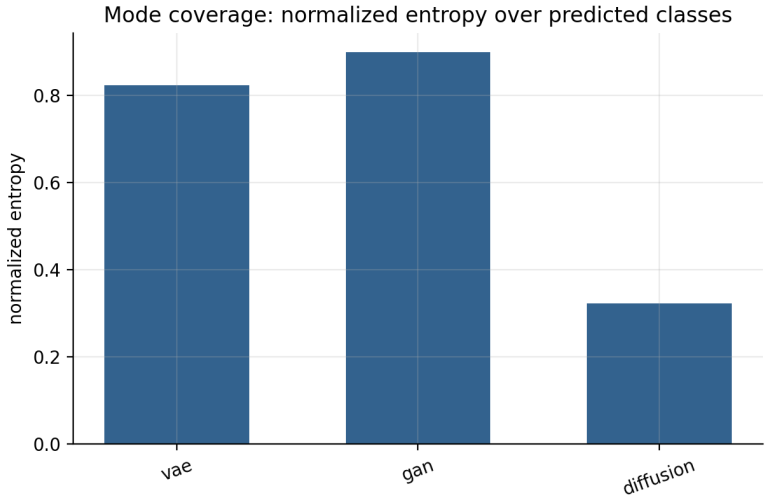


Figure 15. Coverage

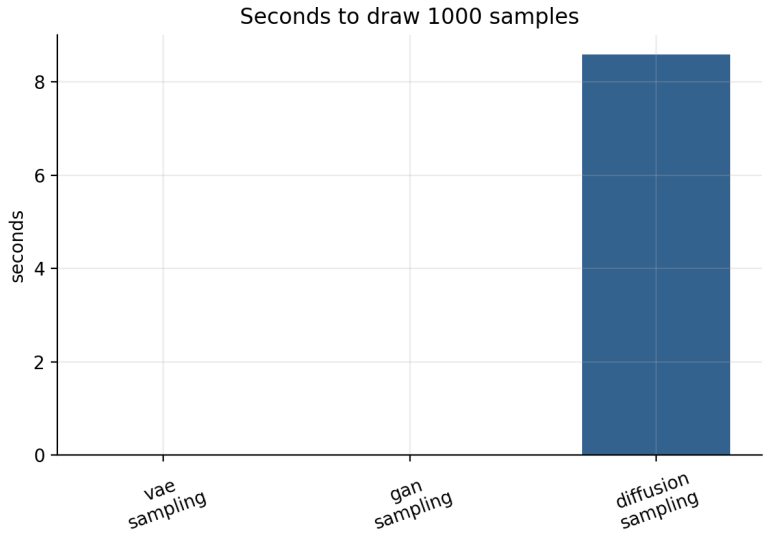


Figure 16. Cost

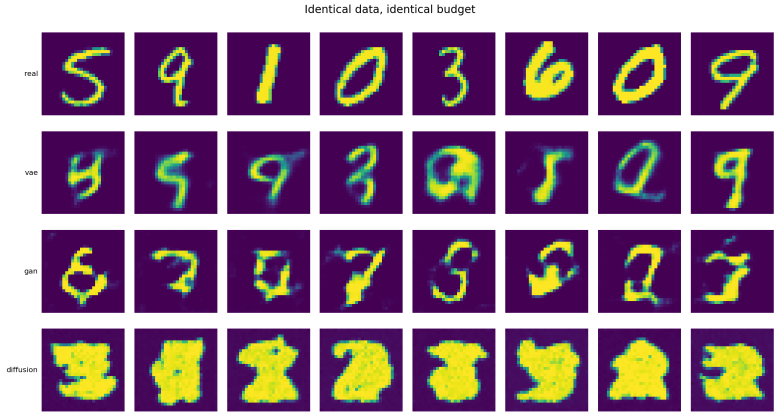


Figure 17. Samples

What surprised me, and what I had to go and check

I expected four distinct winners — one per column — as the cleanest possible demonstration that the question needs a column name. I got **two**: `winner/distinct_axes = 2.0` on every seed. The GAN takes quality and coverage, the VAE takes both speeds, and diffusion wins nothing. That is a worse result for my framing and a fine result for the reader, so it stands.

But diffusion losing *everything* did not sit right, because E3 had scored the same architecture on the same data at fd 2.27. A 10× discrepancy between two rungs of mine is not a finding, it is a bug until proven otherwise. The candidate explanations were the three things E4 does differently: 14 epochs instead of 16, 100 sampling steps instead of 400, and 1000 samples scored instead of 500. So I gridded all three on one T4, and then promoted the answer into the rung itself as a control:

	fd @ 14 epochs	fd @ 16 epochs
100 sampling steps	28.20	3.33
400 sampling steps	4.95	1.17

Sample count changed nothing (27.59 at n=500 against 28.20 at n=1000). **Two more epochs — 14% more budget — is worth 8.5×.** The swept version of that control is now part of E4: `budget_sensitivity/fd_ratio` has a median of **6.40** across seeds [3.79, 8.22], and mode coverage goes from 0.324 to 0.697 entropy over the same two epochs.

And the number that makes it a finding rather than a footnote: over those same two epochs the **training MSE moves 1.6%** — 0.0472 to 0.0465, `budget_sensitivity/mse_ratio = 1.016` [1.009, 1.036]. An 8× change in sample quality is invisible in the loss that produced it.

So the scorecard's honest caption is not "diffusion loses on every axis" but **"an equal-budget comparison measures convergence, not just family"** — and diffusion is the arm sitting on a cliff at this budget. I have left the 14-epoch row as the headline, because equalizing the budget is what the rung set out to do and quietly giving one arm more would be worse, but the control is now reported beside it and the claim is scoped to the budget.

Open threads

The obvious one: sweep the budget itself and report each family's curve rather than one point on it, which is the only construction that would survive this objection. Wall-clock-equal rather than epoch-equal budgets, which would favour the VAE further. And a precision/recall decomposition of fd, which separates "blurry" from "missing modes" in a way a single Fréchet number cannot.

Further reading

GANs Trained by a Two Time-Scale Update Rule (FID); Assessing Generative Models via Precision and Recall; Pros and Cons of GAN Evaluation Measures.

E5 — What E3 becomes in production, priced part by part

Question. Every text-to-image model shipped since 2022 is E3 with three things changed. What does each change cost, and what does it buy?

The idea

Modern text-to-image systems such as Stable Diffusion and FLUX are E3's diffusion model with three parts upgraded:

1. **where** diffusion happens — in the compressed latent space of a trained autoencoder (E1's idea put to work) instead of on raw pixels, which cuts the number of positions the denoiser processes by 64×;
2. **what does the denoising** — a U-Net with text injected by cross-attention (Stable Diffusion), or a transformer that runs joint attention over image and text tokens together (FLUX's **MMDiT**);
3. **what it predicts** — noise (E3, SD) or a *velocity* pointing along a straight path from noise to image (**flow matching**, FLUX), which is why FLUX-schnell needs only 4 sampling steps.

This rung trains nothing. It reads the published configurations and prices each change in positions, attention cost and parameters. Then, in the section after the results, FLUX is actually run.

The architecture figure below (under What I built) shows the three designs side by side.

The math

E3 has three components, and the production lineage replaced them one at a time.

Where the diffusion happens. E3 denoises pixels, so its cost scales with resolution directly. Latent diffusion runs the same chain in the latent space of a trained autoencoder at an $f=8$ downsample, so the positions the denoiser touches fall by f^2:

$$N_{\text{latent}} = \frac{HW}{f^2}, \qquad \frac{N_{\text{pixel}}}{N_{\text{latent}}} = f^2 = 64.$$

A transformer denoiser patchifies on top of that, at $p = 2$, for another p^2: one FLUX token per 16×16 pixels. Since attention is quadratic in positions, a 64× reduction in N is a 4096× reduction in attention work — which is the entire reason E1's VAE is a component of the pipeline rather than a competing family.

How the text gets in. Stable Diffusion's U-Net takes the prompt through cross-attention: image queries against text keys and values, one direction, cost $N_{\text{img}} \cdot N_{\text{txt}}$. MMDiT concatenates the two streams and runs *joint* attention over the union, cost $(N_{\text{img}} + N_{\text{txt}})^2$. The ratio is

$$\frac{(N_{\text{img}} + N_{\text{txt}})^2}{N_{\text{img}} N_{\text{txt}}},$$

which at 1024px with a 512-token prompt is 10.1×. What it buys is that the text representation is updated by the image, not only the reverse.

What the network predicts. E3 regresses the noise a hand-designed schedule added. Flow matching instead learns a velocity field along a straight path between noise and data, which is why its samplers need single-digit step counts where E3's cosine arm was still improving at 400.

What we measure, and why

- **Positions the denoiser processes at 1024 px** — the cost driver, since attention is quadratic in it.
- **Attention cost ratios** — pixel vs latent, and cross-attention vs joint attention: what each design change multiplies the dominant cost by.
- **Parameter counts**, computed from configs and checked against published figures, with the error of each check reported (7.7% for FLUX, 64% for the U-Net estimate). The size of the error says which counts can be trusted.

What I built

Parameter and position accounting for both architectures, read from their published configs and cross-checked against the implementations in the accompanying candle fork (`candle-transformers/src/models/{stable_diffusion, flux}`); both modules are present, and the rung records that rather than assuming it. The MMDiT count reuses `archspec.Transformer`, the same block accounting C5 and H6 use for decoders.

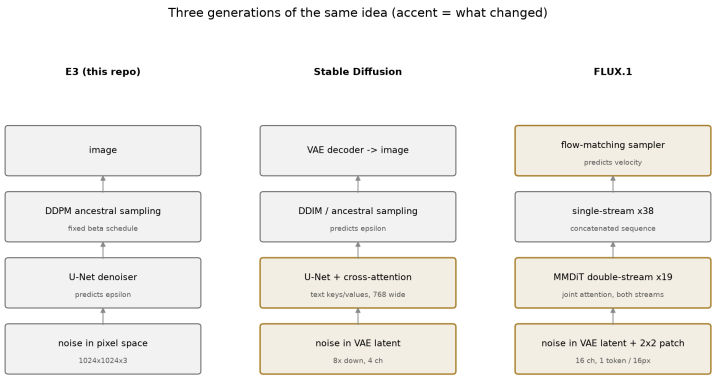


Figure 18. Architectures

Results

	E3 (pixels)	SD-1.5 U-Net	FLUX.1 MMDiT
positions at 1024px	1,048,576	16,384	4,096
conditioning	—	cross-attention, 768-wide	joint, 4096-wide (T5-XXL)
parameters	245k	~308M (estimate)	12.93B
prediction target	ϵ	ϵ	velocity

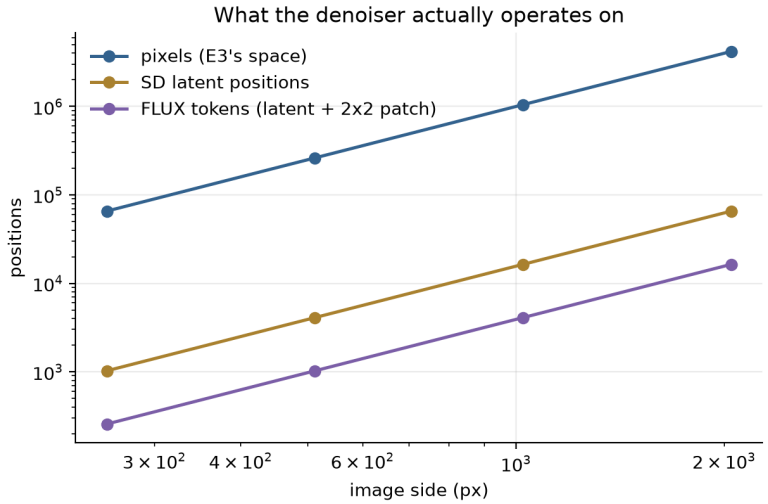


Figure 19. Positions

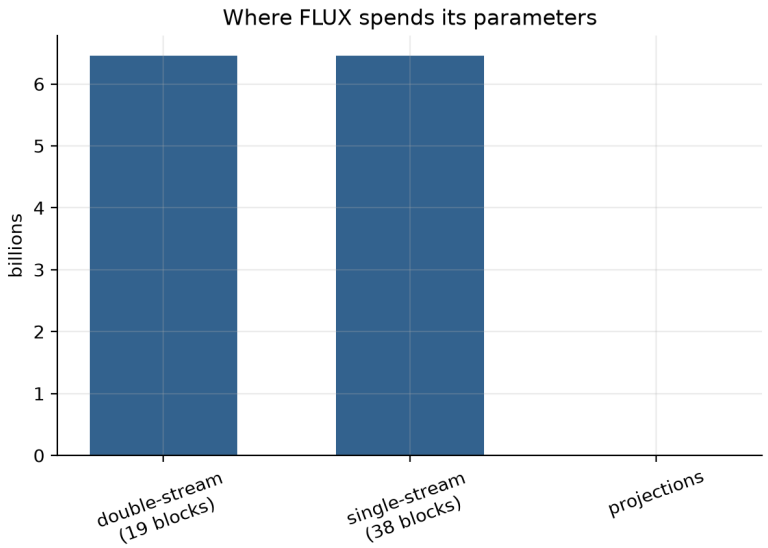


Figure 20. FLUX's budget

FLUX spends its depth asymmetrically: 19 double-stream blocks carry two complete transformer blocks each (separate weights per modality, shared attention), 38 single-stream blocks carry one over the concatenated sequence — and the two halves come out at **6.456B each**, 49.95% single-stream. Twice the blocks for the same parameters, exactly as the "two towers vs one" structure predicts.

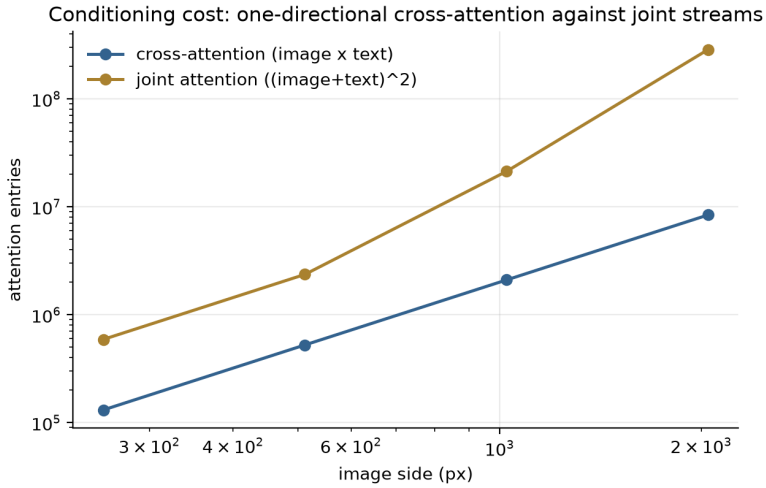


Figure 21. Attention cost

What surprised me

Not the numbers — the *asymmetry in how far I can trust them*. The MMDiT total lands 7.7% under FLUX's published ~12B, close enough that the arithmetic is a real count of a uniform stack. The U-Net estimate lands at 308M against a published ~860M, **64% low**, because it counts convolutions and attention and misses time embeddings, shortcut convolutions and the up-blocks' extra skip channels. Both errors are reported, and the consequence is stated rather than buried: `params/flux_over_sd = 41.9` is computed against my own under-count, so the defensible version of that claim is FLUX ≈ 15× SD's U-Net using the published figure. A regular stack can be counted from a config; an architecture with hand-placed special cases cannot, and that is a fact about architectures, not about my arithmetic.

The other number worth sitting with: E3's pixel-space denoiser at 1024px would attend over 1,048,576 positions against FLUX's 4,096 — **65,536× the attention work**. Latent diffusion is not an optimization on top of E3; it is what makes the family exist at that resolution.

FLUX, actually run

The E5 accounting above is read from a config. FLUX.1-schnell was also run, on a Kaggle T4 (raw record in `data/e-real-models.json`).

route	diffusers `FluxPipeline`, ungated mirror `unsloth/FLUX.1-schnell`
how 12B fit on a 15 GB card	transformer **and** the T5-XXL text encoder quantized to 4-bit NF4 on load, fp16 compute, model-level CPU offload
peak VRAM	**6.53 GB** (the fp16 weights alone would be ~24 GB)
load	381 s
generate, 512×512, 4 steps, no guidance	**19.8 s**

The prompt was "a cross-section diagram of a transformer block, technical illustration, clean white background". FLUX drew an electrical transformer: radiator fins, bushings, isometric line art. That is the dominant sense of the phrase in its training data, and a fair reading of an ambiguous prompt, not a failure. It is also a four-step sample, which is what flow matching's straight paths buy (E3's DDPM was still improving at 400 steps).

The candle route did not produce an image, and the reasons are worth keeping. Three attempts through the accompanying candle fork failed:

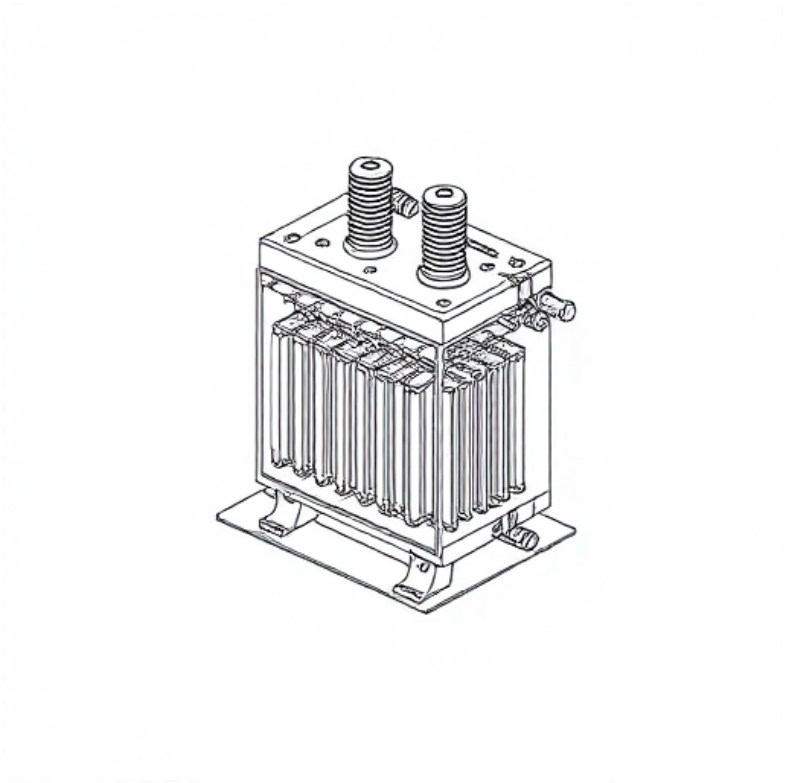


Figure 22. FLUX.1-schnell on a T4

The first Kaggle attempt used *sequential* CPU offload and was killed while loading T5's shards, because offload still materialises every component in host RAM. Quantizing on load is what made the run fit, the same lesson as the decoders in part C.

Open threads

FLUX has now run (above), but through diffusers rather than the candle fork, so the fork's FLUX path is still unexercised on this card; an f16 T5 mirror would cut the download roughly in half and probably bring it inside one session. Checking the parameter count against the *loaded* weights is also still open, and needs care: part C found that `numel` on a 4-bit checkpoint under-counts by exactly 2×. The VAE's own parameters and its reconstruction floor, which upper-bounds everything downstream. And SD3's MMDiT, which is the missing rung between the two columns.

Further reading

High-Resolution Image Synthesis with Latent Diffusion Models; Scaling Rectified Flow Transformers (SD3 / MMDiT); Flow Matching for Generative Modeling.

What part E settled

1. **Every one of these families has a loss that cannot see what you care about, and each fails differently.** The VAE's ELBO falls while the encoder abandons 10 of its 16 latent dimensions. The GAN's loss is a scoreboard in a game whose optimum is $\log 4$ whatever the samples look like. The diffusion MSE moves 1.6% while sample quality moves 8×. Three different mechanisms, one consequence:

in generative modelling the training curve is not a progress bar, and every rung here needed a separate, external scorer to know anything at all.

2. **The metric had to be built before the models could be compared, and it has a known blind spot that must be covered explicitly.** A Fréchet distance is a function of two moments, so mode collapse can hide inside a respectable score; classifying the samples and reporting the histogram's entropy is not decoration. Neither is scoring real held-out data against itself — fd 0.094 is what makes fd 1.76 readable.
3. **The device decided whether a model trained at all.** E2's minimax arm collapsed to fd 590.83 on the CPU at seed 0 and scores 1.81 on the GPU at the same seed. I had published the collapse as the rung's headline result. The correction is the more useful finding: the saturating objective does not reliably fail, it sits close enough to a failure boundary that floating-point differences decide the outcome — which is exactly why it was abandoned.
4. **An equal-budget comparison measures convergence as much as family.** E4's diffusion arm loses every column at 14 epochs and is 6.4× better at 16, with the training loss flat across the difference. The scorecard is still the right construction; what changed is that it now carries the control that scopes it, because "all three had the same budget" is only a fair statement if all three are near the flat part of their curve, and one of them was not.
5. **The improvements the literature made are large-scale results, and a small rung should expect not to reproduce them.** Cosine schedules did not beat linear here (`cosine_gain/fd` median −0.036, range [−1.08, +0.31]), and the step-count "knee" turned out to be a property of the schedule rather than of diffusion — 400 steps on cosine, 50 on linear. Neither result contradicts the papers; both contradict quoting the papers' conclusions at $T = 400$ on a 245k-parameter U-Net.
6. **The production lineage is three independent changes to E3, and their prices are very different.** Latent diffusion is a 64× reduction in positions and a 65,536× reduction in attention work at 1024px — a change of feasibility, not of degree. Joint attention costs 10.1× the cross-attention it replaces and buys bidirectional conditioning. Flow matching changes what is predicted and is why production samplers need single-digit steps where E3's cosine arm was still improving at 400.
7. **A uniform stack can be counted from its config; an architecture with hand-placed special cases cannot.** The MMDiT arithmetic lands 7.7% under FLUX's published size; the same style of accounting applied to SD's U-Net lands 64% low. Both errors are reported, and the derived ratio built on the bad one (`params/flux_over_sd = 41.9`) is stated with its correction (≈15× against the published figure) rather than quoted as a result.

Cost of the part: ~2,600 lines including tests, 39 test cases, and a three-seed sweep in about 17 minutes on a T4 (E1 23s, E2 36s, E3 163s, E4 98s + 50s for the convergence control, E5 2s per seed). E3 dominates because it trains two schedules and samples each at five step counts; E5 is arithmetic.

Figures regenerate with `uv run python tools/writeup_figures.py E`; the numbers they are quoted against live in `data/e-metrics.json`. The part README is the short version of this document.